

plans. The increased use of public cloud services has reinforced cloud adoption to be the 'new normal,' now more than ever."

One of the key factors that cloud service companies must take care of, is reliability, which will become critical with increasing reliance on cloud services. Mike Tria, Head of Platform at Atlassian explains, "software companies will be held to higher numbers of reliability. In fact, three 9's as a reliability metric (or 99.9% uptime) will be laughed at in a few years. As companies rely more on cloud services to collaborate remotely, customers will have higher expectations for uptime. Companies that don't treat reliability as a feature will be left in the dust. Automation will be inevitable in 2021. As more engineering organizations migrate their infrastructure to the cloud and adopt a microservices architecture, the next challenge they'll face is figuring out how to manage and keep pace with an unwieldy, distributed system. Whereas, automation has been seen as an emerging tool in the past, it will become essential for survival in 2021."

11 DISTRIBUTED WORKFORCE

Dell Technologies conducted a survey of 7,000 working professionals in the Asia Pacific and Japan region, to investigate the preparedness and readiness of workers to permanently adopt a work from home model, as well as the challenges they face when working remotely. The research showed that in India, 30 per cent of the respondents had a problem with using personal tools and equipment for work purposes, struggled with connectivity issues and accessing internal company resources through the internet, and wanted access to collaboration and communication tools. Among all the countries surveyed, India had the most number of respondents who had previously worked from home, ahead of both Indonesia and Japan. One of the primary concerns for the Indian respondents was a problematic blurring of lines between personal

time and company time, an issue that was even more pronounced among those working in small and medium sized businesses.

A staggering 91 per cent of respondents were willing to work from home permanently, but were facing issues when it came to their



Credit: JSC/NASA

Based on popular demand, NASA employees working remotely posted a gallery of their furry friends. Do not worry, no cats commandeered a Mars rover during the outbreak.

productivity in a remote working environment. Indrajit Belgundi, Senior Director & General Manager, Client Solutions Group at Dell Technologies, India, explains how organizations should take the initiative when it comes to addressing remote working concerns, "the events of 2020 have led organisations to adapt to new ways of working and rethink how work can be conducted. As organisations come to terms with the new reality where a hybrid workplace will be the norm, factors conducive to productivity, in the long run, need to be considered. India as one of the countries across the APJ region, has had experience with remote work and is displaying readiness for long term remote and digital teams. For CIOs and their teams who displayed agility and speed in achieving or embarking upon digital transformation for their business earlier this year, it has become clear that the onus is on the organisation to enable employees with support available at every stage. This will be essential to establishing a productive and connected digital workforce."

The distributed work environment also introduces new wrinkles to the

cybersecurity practices. Experts are of the opinion that again, here organisations must take the lead to explain the security requirements and concerns to their employees. "The global pandemic has been the largest test yet for the future of distributed work. Working people have proven incredibly resilient as they rise to the challenge and overcome the stress and significant obstacles of blending home and work lives," says Matt Cohen, Chief Operating Officer at CyberArk. "As we continue to adapt to this new way of operating, it's the responsibility of both employees and organisations to take responsibility of corporate security. Organisations should continually reinforce best practices and implement user-friendly tools and policies while employees need to understand and be receptive to those policies."

12 EVOLVING CLOUD SECURITY

The accelerating cloudification combined with distributed work has introduced new security challenges when it comes to cybersecurity, for both the individual and the organisation. To start with, the amount of cybersecurity threats in the machines of people spiked after the pandemic, and the reason could be related to the pandemic, or just because the machines were being used more. Acronis, in its communications has warned of attacks on the remote workforce increasing, for the simple reason that the bad actors have easier access to the less secure systems of the remote workers. Denis Staforkin, Security Expert at Kaspersky explains, "Over the past year, our detection systems discovered far more new malicious objects than they did in 2019. Due to the pandemic, users from around the world were forced to spend more time on their devices and online. It's hard to know whether or not attackers